THEORY LAB · 04

Trivial theory is not a failure of intelligence. It is a failure of variation.

Weick, 1989, published in the same issue as Whetten's four building blocks, and arguing against the way most of us were taught.

THE COMPLAINT

Theorists write trivial theories because they let methodology dominate.

Trained to worry about validation from the first sentence, they generate cautious, look-alike conjectures, then test them against a single question: will this survive?

The result is safe and dull, and the field mistakes the dullness for rigour.

Three dials. Turn any one up and theory quality rises.

1 PROBLEM STATEMENTS, fuller, more accurate, more explicit about assumptions. They open more solution paths.

2 THOUGHT TRIALS, more conjectures, and more independent of one another.

3 SELECTION CRITERIA, more criteria, more diverse, applied consistently.

WEICK'S VOCABULARY

The machine, in four terms

Thought trials

Conjectures run mentally against a problem. More of them, and more unlike one another, produce better theory. Dependent trials do not count as separate trials.

Selection criteria

The tests a conjecture must survive, plausible, consistent, elegant, useful, interesting. More criteria, more diverse, applied consistently.

Artificial selection

Why theorising differs from evolution: the theorist is both the source of variation and the agent of selection, so both can be deliberately improved.

“That's interesting” as a significance test

With validation unavailable at the moment of theorising, the felt sense of interest substitutes for it, because it marks an assumption being falsified.

Where theorising quietly fails: one trial, stretched

1 Little men often start arguments in the presence of big men

2 ... little people ...

3 ... the physically disadvantaged ...

4 "Among people, inequalities in one domain lead to aggression in another"

WHY THAT LADDER FAILS

If trial two is shaped by trial one, you have not run two trials.

Each rung depended on the one below it. That is one thought trial stretched, not several.

And in generalising MEN to PEOPLE, the proposition lost the ability to explain the observation it came from. Generality bought at the cost of the problem it was meant to solve.

Weick's warning on the third dial: “Every conjecture can satisfy some criterion.” Shift your criteria mid-stream and nothing is ever rejected.

A LINK BACK TO WEEK 1

“That's interesting” is the working substitute for “that's valid.”

Validation is largely unavailable at the moment of theorising. So the theorist needs a signal that works in its place.

Interest is that signal, not because it is flashy, but because the feeling marks the moment an assumption you held has just been falsified.

Davis's mechanism, three weeks earlier, doing load-bearing work inside a theory of how theory gets built.

SOURCES

Weick, K. E. (1989). Theory construction as disciplined imagination. Academy of Management Review, 14(4), 516–531.

Bacharach, S. B. (1989). Organizational theories: Some criteria for evaluation. AMR, 14(4), 496–515.

Weick, K. E. (1999). Theory construction as disciplined reflexivity: Tradeoffs in the 90s. AMR, 24(4), 797–806.

Lave, C. A., & March, J. G. (1975). An introduction to models in the social sciences. Harper & Row.

An honest limit: “disciplined imagination” is quoted to license whatever the speaker was going to do anyway, and the half that gets dropped is always DISCIPLINED. Weick asks for more criteria applied more consistently, a harder standard, not a softer one.

THE QUESTION

How many explanations did you seriously consider before settling on the one in your paper?

If the answer is one, you did not select a theory. You accepted the first one that arrived.

Next week: research design, and problematization, where a question that is worth asking actually comes from.

Answer honestly in the comments